

UNIT VI

The Whole World at War



World War II · 1939–1945

US.45

US.46

US.47

US.48

US.49

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US.51

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US.58

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

World War II asked the United States to save democracy abroad — while it was still denying democracy to millions of its own people at home. Can a country fight for freedom in the world and against it at home, at the same time? And when winning the war meant building the most terrible weapon ever made — in Tennessee — what did victory finally cost?

This is the big one — the war that pulled in the whole world and killed more people than any event in human history. World War II is a story of almost unimaginable extremes: the greatest evil (the Holocaust and the fascism that produced it) and enormous courage; the fight for freedom abroad and the denial of it at home; the biggest industrial effort ever mounted and the most terrible weapon ever built. You'll live it through six people. Frankie, the reporter, witnesses it all. Sal, a Brooklyn kid, wades onto Omaha Beach. Marcus becomes a Tuskegee Airman, fighting fascism in a segregated uniform. Kimi, an American citizen, is imprisoned by her own government for being Japanese American. Faye builds bombers in Nashville. And Hazel takes a secret job in the East Tennessee hills that turns out to be building the atomic bomb. Tennessee is not a bystander in this story — it is at the very center of it, from the battleship USS Tennessee at Pearl Harbor to the secret city of Oak Ridge to the Tennessean who fathered the United Nations. Your job is to hold the whole thing honestly: the heroism and the hypocrisy, the victory and its terrible price.

How this unit works

- Taught through story — you meet a soldier, a pilot, a prisoner, and two workers before you meet a single battle.
- Multiple perspectives — the soldier and the civilian, the celebrated and the interned, the victory and its cost, each given a fair and dignified voice.
- Primary sources — FDR's own words, the executive orders themselves, the UN Charter, and the era's most powerful photographs.
- UDL — a present-day hook, plain-language summaries, cited images, and a choice of ways to respond on every spread.
- Freedom abroad vs. freedom at home — the unit's spine: a democracy fighting for liberty while denying it to its own.
- The Arc of the Union — plot the war's climbs and its deepest setbacks, and weigh the atomic bomb on the nation-power-vs-human-cost axis.

Flight crew this unit:

Archive (J. Troop)

Spark

Navigator

Notetaker

Who you'll travel with in this unit



Frankie, 37

On assignment —
London, Normandy,
the Pacific



Sal, 19

Brooklyn → Normandy
and beyond



Marcus, 21

Harlem → Tuskegee →
Italy



Kimi, 16

Hayward, California →
an internment camp



Faye, 20

Nashville, Tennessee



Hazel, 19

Oak Ridge, Tennessee

Spread 1 • US.45, US.46

Analyze the rise of fascism and totalitarianism in Europe, and how FDR moved a reluctant America from isolationism toward supporting the democracies.

 Picture a hundred thousand people packed into a stadium at night, torches blazing, every arm raised in perfect unison to one man on a distant stage. It's designed to make you feel like part of something huge and unstoppable — and to make anyone who disagrees feel utterly alone. That was fascism's genius, and in the 1930s it was winning. Across an ocean, most Americans just wanted to look away. This is the story of a monster rising, and a country slowly deciding it couldn't pretend not to see.

Archive takes the C-130 low over a torchlit Nazi rally, then banks west across the Atlantic to a quiet American main street. 'Two worlds,' she says. 'One is building a machine to conquer the other — and the other just wants to be left alone. Watch how long 'left alone' can last.'

INSTITUTION

The dictators • fascism on the march

In the wreckage after World War I, a terrifying new kind of government rose. Fascism — extreme nationalism, worship of military power, a single all-powerful leader, and the scapegoating of minorities — took hold in Italy under Mussolini in 1922 and, catastrophically, in Germany under Adolf Hitler in 1933. In the Soviet Union, Stalin built a totalitarian communist state that controlled every corner of life. These regimes shared a method: total control, relentless propaganda, and the crushing of anyone who resisted. And they were expansionist. By the late 1930s they were rearming, invading their neighbors, and menacing every democracy left standing.

PRIMARY VOICE

Franklin D. Roosevelt • the Four Freedoms

Most Americans, scarred by the last war and the Depression, were isolationists — they wanted no part of Europe's fight. FDR understood that feeling and moved carefully, but he also saw the danger clearly, and step by step he nudged the country toward engagement. In 1941 he named what was at stake: 'four essential human freedoms' — freedom of speech, freedom of worship, freedom from want, and freedom from fear — that he said belonged to people everywhere. Through the Atlantic Charter with Churchill and the Lend-Lease Act, FDR made the U.S. the 'arsenal of democracy,' supplying the Allies with weapons before a single American soldier joined the fight.



📷 SA troops march past Adolf Hitler at the 1935 Nazi Party rally in Nuremberg — mass spectacle designed to display totalitarian power.

'Reichsparteitag of the NSDAP in Nuremberg — SA troops march past Adolf Hitler.' Photograph, September 1935. Public domain.

💡 This is a 1935 Nazi rally at Nuremberg — tens of thousands marching in perfect formation past Hitler. Ask: the Nazis staged these events on purpose, as theater. What is a spectacle like this designed to make people feel — and why is that feeling so dangerous?

In plain words: After World War I, fascism rose in Europe: Mussolini in Italy (1922) and Hitler in Germany (1933) built dictatorships based on extreme nationalism, military power, and scapegoating minorities, while Stalin ran a totalitarian USSR. These aggressive regimes threatened democracies everywhere. Most Americans were isolationist — they wanted to stay out. But President Roosevelt slowly moved the country toward helping the Allies, naming the 'Four Freedoms' worth defending and passing Lend-Lease (1941) to send weapons to Britain before the U.S. entered the war.

● **Tennessee:** A Tennessean helped steer America's turn toward the world. Cordell Hull, from the hills of Middle Tennessee, served as FDR's Secretary of State from 1933 to 1944 — longer than anyone in history. Hull pushed to lower trade barriers and warned against the rising fascist powers, working to pull the United States out of isolationism. The Tennessean you first met championing the League of Nations in Unit 3 was now, decades later, at FDR's right hand as the world slid toward war.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Aggressive fascist powers threatened the world's democracies while the U.S. wanted to stay out.
- **Head out of the sand:** FDR and internationalists who saw the danger, against a strong isolationist public.
- **Voice raised:** Presidential leadership (Four Freedoms, fireside chats) and congressional debate over aid to the Allies.
- **Government response:** Lend-Lease and the Atlantic Charter committed the U.S. to arming the Allies short of war.
- **Still unfinished:** When and whether to intervene against tyranny abroad remains a defining American debate.

✓ **Check:** Define fascism and give two examples of fascist or totalitarian regimes. Then explain why most Americans were isolationist, and how FDR moved the country toward helping the Allies before Pearl Harbor.

Show what you know:

- Analyze the Nuremberg rally photo: list three techniques the Nazis used to project power, and why each works.
 - Write FDR's short radio pitch to a skeptical isolationist family for why America should help Britain.
 - Debate: was American isolationism in the 1930s understandable, foolish, or both? Use evidence.
-

Spread 2 · US.48, US.49

Analyze the attack on Pearl Harbor and U.S. entry into the war, and identify the key Allied leaders and their roles.

🔊 It's a sleepy Sunday morning. Sailors are still in their bunks, some at breakfast, the band tuning up for the flag-raising. And then the sky fills with planes that shouldn't be there, and in under two hours everything changes — 2,400 people dead, a fleet in flames, and a country that swore it would never fight again suddenly, furiously, at war. Some mornings split history into 'before' and 'after.' December 7, 1941 was one of them.

Archive holds the crew above Pearl Harbor as the first bombs fall. Frankie's already scribbling. 'Yesterday half this country wanted nothing to do with the war,' Archive says. 'By tomorrow, there won't be a half. Watch a single morning erase years of argument.'



ERA-FRIEND

Frankie · a date that will live in infamy

Frankie files the story that ends American isolationism. On the morning of December 7, 1941, Japan launches a surprise attack on the U.S. naval base at Pearl Harbor, Hawaii — no declaration of war, the bombs falling while Japanese diplomats are still talking in Washington. In under two hours, more than 2,400 Americans are killed and the Pacific Fleet is devastated. The next day President Roosevelt calls it 'a date which will live in infamy' and asks Congress to declare war. Frankie has watched the country argue about this for years; now, overnight, the argument is over. Days later, Germany and Italy declare war on the United States, and America is in the whole war, on both sides of the world.

INSTITUTION

The Allied leaders · who steered the war

A war this vast turned on a handful of leaders. Winston Churchill, Britain's defiant prime minister, kept his island in the fight during its darkest hours. Franklin Roosevelt led the American war effort until his death in April 1945. Dwight D. Eisenhower, as Supreme Commander in Europe, coordinated the sprawling Allied armies and planned D-Day. Douglas MacArthur commanded in the Pacific, vowing 'I shall return' to the Philippines. And when FDR died near the war's end, a little-known vice president, Harry S. Truman, inherited the most fateful decision in modern history: whether to use the atomic bomb.



📷 The destroyer USS Shaw explodes during the Japanese surprise attack on Pearl Harbor, December 7, 1941.

'USS Shaw exploding during the Japanese raid on Pearl Harbor.' U.S. Navy photograph (80-G-16871), December 7, 1941. Public domain.

💡 This is the destroyer USS Shaw exploding at Pearl Harbor, December 7, 1941. Ask: images like this ran in every newspaper within days. How does a single photograph of a burning ship turn a distant policy debate into a personal call to action for millions of people?

In plain words: On December 7, 1941, Japan launched a surprise attack on the U.S. naval base at Pearl Harbor, Hawaii, killing about 2,400 Americans and crippling the Pacific Fleet. President Roosevelt called it 'a date which will live in infamy,' and Congress declared war on Japan; Germany and Italy then declared war on the U.S. Isolationism ended overnight. The war was steered by key Allied leaders: Churchill (Britain), FDR then Truman (U.S.), Eisenhower (Europe/D-Day), and MacArthur (Pacific).

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee's name was in the harbor that morning. The battleship USS Tennessee was moored at Pearl Harbor on December 7, 1941, and was damaged in the attack but survived to fight on. In the years that followed, roughly 300,000 Tennesseans served in the war around the globe — the state was in this fight from the very first minutes.

✓ **Check:** Explain what happened at Pearl Harbor and why it ended American isolationism. Then identify two Allied leaders and each one's role in the war.

Show what you know:

- Write the front-page lede Frankie files the night of December 7, 1941.
 - Make a quick 'who's who' card set for the five Allied leaders, with one line on each.
 - Debate: why do surprise attacks like Pearl Harbor unite a divided country so completely? Use evidence.
-

Spread 3 • US.50

Analyze the major American military campaigns in the European and Pacific theaters — D-Day, Midway, and the island-hopping fight to Iwo Jima.

🔊 You're nineteen, in a flat-bottomed boat crossing a freezing sea toward a beach you've never seen. The ramp drops. Ahead is open sand, then cliffs, then machine guns firing down at everything that moves. Your job is to run into it. Multiply that terror by 160,000 men on a single morning, and you have D-Day — the largest invasion in human history, and the beginning of the end for Nazi Germany. This is what winning actually looked like, up close.

Archive drops the crew into the surf off Normandy at dawn on June 6, 1944. Sal is in the boat ahead, white-knuckled. 'Everything you've read about this war comes down to men like Sal getting off this boat,' Archive says quietly. 'Watch what ordinary courage costs.'



ERA-FRIEND

Sal • into the jaws of death

Sal is a nineteen-year-old from Brooklyn, the grandson of immigrants, and on June 6, 1944 — D-Day — he wades onto Omaha Beach in Normandy. The invasion is the largest amphibious assault in history: nearly 160,000 Allied troops crossing the English Channel to open a western front against Nazi Germany. Omaha is one of the deadliest landing zones, a killing ground of open sand under fortified German guns. Sal watches friends fall in the surf and keeps moving because stopping is death. The beachhead holds, and from it the Allies begin the long, bloody push toward Germany — but Sal will never forget the price of the sand under his boots.

INSTITUTION

Two oceans • the shape of the war

Sal's beach was one front of a two-theater war. In Europe, after Normandy, the Allies survived Germany's last big counterattack at the Battle of the Bulge and drove into Germany from the west while the Soviets closed in from the east. In the Pacific, the U.S. Navy's victory at Midway in 1942 turned the tide against Japan, and then came 'island-hopping' — seizing key islands one brutal battle at a time, like Iwo Jima and Okinawa, each closer to Japan itself. It was a war of staggering scale and cost: more than 400,000 Americans died before it was over.



📷 'Into the Jaws of Death' — U.S. troops waded ashore under fire at Omaha Beach on D-Day, June 6, 1944, the largest amphibious invasion in history.

Sargent, Robert F. 'Into the Jaws of Death — U.S. troops wading ashore at Omaha Beach.' U.S. Coast Guard photograph, June 6, 1944. Public domain.

💡 This is 'Into the Jaws of Death' — soldiers wading onto Omaha Beach on D-Day, photographed from a landing craft. Ask: the photographer took this while under the same fire as the soldiers. What does it change to know the person who made an image was risking everything to make it?

In plain words: World War II was fought in two main theaters. In Europe, the D-Day invasion of Normandy (June 6, 1944) — the largest amphibious assault ever, with ~160,000 Allied troops — opened a western front that, with the Soviet advance from the east, led to Germany's defeat. In the Pacific, the U.S. won the turning-point Battle of Midway (1942), then fought a brutal 'island-hopping' campaign (Iwo Jima, Okinawa) toward Japan. More than 400,000 Americans died in the war.

● **Tennessee:** Tennesseans were in the thick of these campaigns. The roughly 300,000 Tennesseans who served fought in Normandy and across the Pacific islands, and Tennessee produced multiple Medal of Honor recipients in the war. The beaches and islands in the famous photographs were crossed by Tennessee farm boys and city kids alongside Americans from every other state.

✓ **Check:** Describe the significance of D-Day and one Pacific campaign. Explain how the two-theater war led toward Allied victory, and give one detail that conveys its human cost.

Show what you know:

- Write Sal's letter home the night after the Normandy landing — the parts he can and can't say.
 - Make a two-theater map marking D-Day, the Bulge, Midway, Iwo Jima, and Okinawa with one fact each.
 - Debate: was the Pacific island-hopping strategy worth its terrible cost? Use evidence.
-

Spread 4 • US.47

Analyze the Holocaust and the evolving U.S. response — from refusing Jewish refugees before the war to liberating the camps at its end.

🔔 Before the shooting ever reached America, a ship full of desperate people sailed to within sight of the Florida coast — and was turned away. Nine hundred Jewish refugees, fleeing a government that wanted them dead, sent back to Europe because America wouldn't take them in. Years later, American soldiers would open the gates of the death camps and finally see, with their own eyes, exactly what those refugees had been fleeing. This is the war's most painful lesson: the difference between fighting evil and stopping it in time.

Archive brings the crew to a camp's gates alongside the first American soldiers, in the spring of 1945. She doesn't narrate. 'Some things you do not explain,' she says softly. 'You bear witness, carefully and truthfully, and you make sure they are never forgotten. Look — with respect.'

INSTITUTION

The Holocaust • a systematic genocide

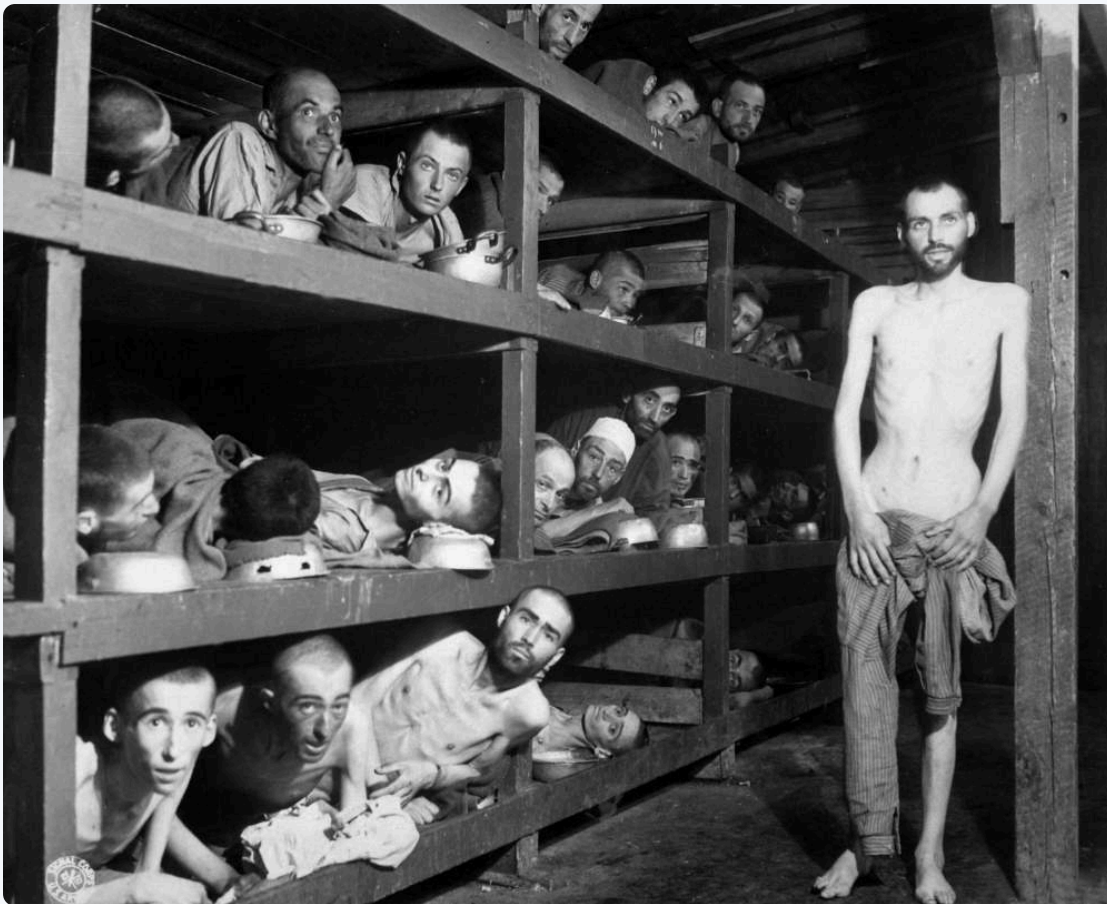
At the heart of Nazi evil was the Holocaust: the deliberate, systematic murder of six million Jews, along with millions of others — Roma, disabled people, Poles, prisoners, and political opponents — carried out in ghettos, mass shootings, and industrial death camps. This was not a byproduct of war; it was a planned genocide, the horror at the center of everything the Allies were fighting against. Understanding World War II without understanding the Holocaust is impossible: it is the clearest reason the word 'evil' belongs in a history book at all.



ERA-FRIEND

Frankie • what America did, and didn't, do

Frankie has to report the hardest truth: America's response was late and, at first, closed. Before the war, tight immigration quotas and prejudice led the U.S. to turn away Jewish refugees — most infamously the SS St. Louis in 1939, a ship of over 900 refugees sent back to Europe, where many later died in the Holocaust. Then, as Allied armies advanced in 1945, American troops liberated the camps and saw the horror firsthand; General Eisenhower ordered it all documented so the world could never deny it. Frankie writes the whole, uncomfortable arc: a country that helped defeat this evil, but that could have saved more of its victims and chose not to.



📷 Survivors in the barracks at Buchenwald concentration camp, five days after U.S. forces liberated it in April 1945 (future Nobel laureate Elie Wiesel is in the photo).

'Buchenwald survivors in the barracks after liberation.' U.S. Army photograph, April 16, 1945. Public domain.

💡 This photograph shows survivors at Buchenwald days after American soldiers liberated the camp in April 1945. Eisenhower deliberately ordered scenes like this documented. Ask: why did a general insist the world SEE this — and what responsibility comes with looking at an image like this today?

In plain words: The Holocaust was Nazi Germany's systematic murder of six million Jews and millions of others — a planned genocide, the ultimate evil the Allies fought. America's response changed over time. Before the war, U.S. immigration limits and prejudice turned away Jewish refugees, including the ship SS St. Louis (1939), sent back to Europe where many died. As the war ended in 1945, American soldiers liberated the Nazi camps, and General Eisenhower ordered the horrors documented so no one could ever deny them.

🟡 **Tennessee:** Tennessee soldiers were among the Americans who advanced across Europe in 1945 and encountered the Nazi camps, becoming witnesses to the Holocaust and, for the rest of their lives, testimony that it happened. The roughly 300,000 Tennesseans who served carried home not just the memory of battle but, for some, the unforgettable sight of what fascism had done.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** A genocidal regime murdered millions while the world, including the U.S., was slow to act or admit refugees.
- **Head out of the sand:** Refugees who tried to flee, and soldiers, reporters, and leaders who documented the truth.
- **Voice raised:** Wartime reporting, the soldiers' testimony, and Eisenhower's insistence on documentation.
- **Government response:** The U.S. helped defeat Nazi Germany and later admitted survivors (Displaced Persons Act, 1948), after earlier turning refugees away.
- **Still unfinished:** How and when the world intervenes against genocide remains an unanswered moral question.

✓ **Check:** Explain what the Holocaust was, and describe how the U.S. response evolved from before the war to its end. Why did Eisenhower order the camps documented?

Show what you know:

- Write a short, respectful reflection on why Eisenhower insisted the camps be documented and photographed.
 - Research the SS St. Louis and explain, in a paragraph, what its story asks of a nation's conscience.
 - Create a fact-based timeline of the U.S. response to the Holocaust, from the 1939 quotas to the 1945 liberations.
-

Spread 5 • US.51, US.53

Analyze how Americans who faced discrimination at home — the Tuskegee Airmen and Black defense workers — fought for a 'Double V': victory abroad and at home.

🔊 Imagine risking your life for a country that makes you use a separate water fountain. You put on the uniform, you fly the missions, you bleed for the flag — and when you come home, you still can't vote, still can't eat at the counter, still get called a slur by the people you protected. That was the impossible position of Black Americans in World War II. And instead of giving up on their country, they made a demand that still echoes: victory over fascism abroad AND victory over racism at home. They called it the Double V.

Archive lands the crew at an airfield in Italy where sleek fighters wait, then flashes to a defense plant back home. 'Same country, same war, two battles,' she says. 'These Americans are fighting Hitler in the sky and Jim Crow on the ground — at the same time. Watch them refuse to choose.'



ERA-FRIEND

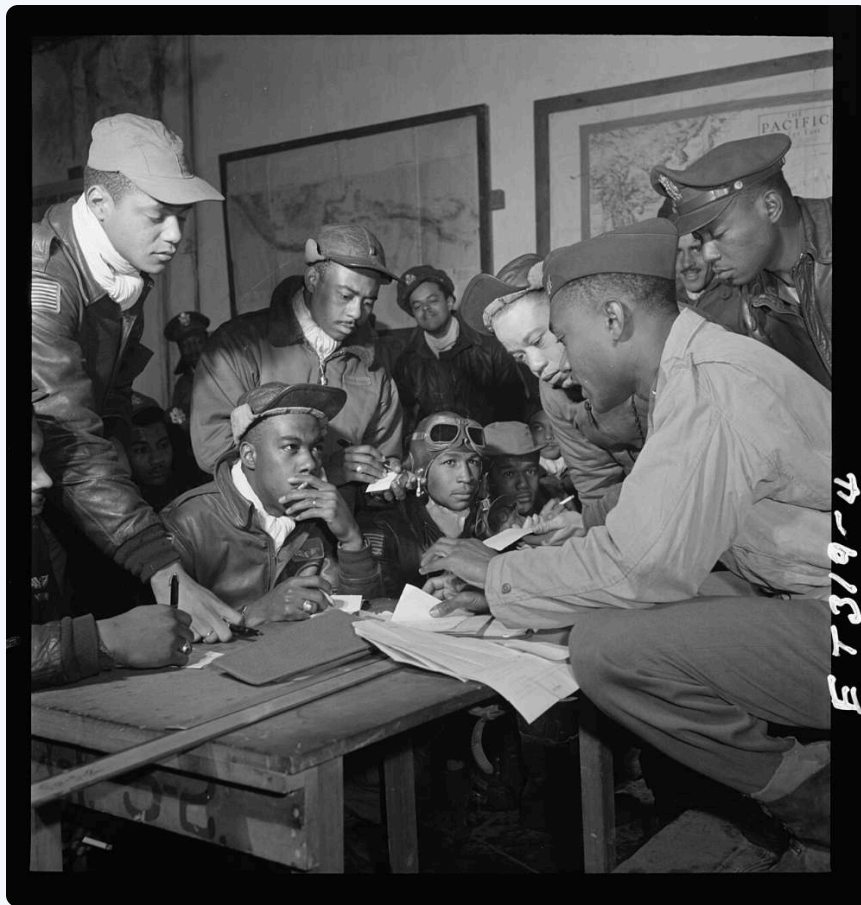
Marcus • a Tuskegee Airman

Marcus is Ruth's younger brother, out of Harlem, and he becomes something his country said was impossible: a military pilot. Trained at Tuskegee, Alabama, he and his fellow Tuskegee Airmen are the first African American aviators in the U.S. armed forces, flying fighter escort for Allied bombers over Europe and compiling an outstanding record protecting the planes they guard. They do it inside a segregated military, under officers and a public who doubt they can even fly. Every mission Marcus flies is an argument written in the sky: that the country's belief about what a Black man can do is simply, provably wrong.

INSTITUTION

The Double V • two victories or none

Marcus is one front of a larger movement. As the war created millions of defense jobs, Black leaders demanded a share; when A. Philip Randolph threatened a march on Washington, FDR signed Executive Order 8802 in 1941, banning racial discrimination in the defense industry — the first federal action against employment discrimination. Hundreds of thousands of Black Americans took new industrial jobs as the Great Migration continued. Across it all ran the 'Double V' campaign: victory over fascism abroad and victory over racism at home. Black Americans served and worked and demanded — and the contradiction they exposed would fuel the civil-rights movement to come.



 Tuskegee Airmen of the 332nd Fighter Group in Italy, March 1945 — the first African American military pilots, who flew bomber-escort missions while facing segregation at home.

Frissell, Toni. 'Tuskegee Airmen, 332nd Fighter Group, Ramitelli, Italy.' Photograph, March 1945. Library of Congress (public domain).

 These are Tuskegee Airmen in Italy in 1945 — among the first Black pilots in U.S. history. Ask: they fought fascism abroad while segregated at home. How does that contradiction change the way you read the pride on their faces in this photograph?



Black and white workers on the same aircraft assembly line in 1942 — a change made possible by Executive Order 8802 banning discrimination in defense jobs.

In plain words: Black Americans fought World War II on two fronts. The Tuskegee Airmen became the first African American military pilots, flying bomber-escort missions with an excellent record — while serving in a segregated military that doubted them. At home, Black leaders won Executive Order 8802 (1941), which banned discrimination in defense jobs, and hundreds of thousands took new industrial work. Their 'Double V' campaign demanded victory over fascism abroad AND racism at home. This wartime experience helped fuel the later civil-rights movement.

● **Tennessee:** Black Tennesseans lived the Double V too. They served in the segregated military and took the new defense-industry jobs opened by Executive Order 8802, part of the continuing Great Migration out of the rural South. The pride and the anger of fighting for a country that treated them as second-class fed directly into the civil-rights movement that Tennessee — from Nashville's lunch counters to Memphis — would help lead a generation later.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Black Americans were asked to fight for freedom abroad while denied it at home.
- **Head out of the sand:** Black servicemembers, workers, and leaders like A. Philip Randolph and the Double V press.
- **Voice raised:** The threatened 1941 March on Washington, the Double V campaign, and distinguished military service.
- **Government response:** FDR's Executive Order 8802 (1941) banned defense-job discrimination; the military was integrated by Truman in 1948.
- **Still unfinished:** Full equality remained unwon — the war lit the fuse for the civil-rights movement to come.

✓ **Check:** Explain the 'Double V' campaign. Use the Tuskegee Airmen and Executive Order 8802 as examples of Black Americans fighting on two fronts. How did this experience connect to the later civil-rights movement?

Show what you know:

- Design a 'Double V' poster and explain the two victories it demands.
 - Write the letter Marcus sends his sister Ruth after his first combat mission — pride and anger together.
 - Debate: did World War II help or hurt the cause of civil rights? Use evidence from this spread.
-

Spread 6 • US.52, US.55

Analyze how the war transformed women's roles (Rosie the Riveter) and required total civilian mobilization (rationing, bonds, POW camps) on the home front.

🔊 They told women their place was the kitchen — right up until the country needed them to build the bombers. Almost overnight, millions of women who'd been told they couldn't do 'men's work' were welding ships and riveting warplanes, and doing it brilliantly. Meanwhile everybody else was saving bacon grease, planting gardens, and turning in scrap metal for the war. This is the home front: the story of how winning a world war took every single person, not just the ones holding a rifle.

Archive sets the crew down on the floor of a roaring Nashville aircraft plant. Faye is up on a wing with a drill. 'The war isn't only over there,' Archive says over the din. 'It's being built right here, in Tennessee, by people the world underestimated. Watch a country discover what its women can do.'



ERA-FRIEND

Faye • a Tennessee Rosie

Faye is twenty, and before the war her future looked narrow. Then Pearl Harbor empties the factories of men, and the defense industry, desperate for workers, does the once-unthinkable: it hires women by the millions. Faye goes to work at the Vultee aircraft plant in Nashville, drilling and riveting the dive bombers that will fly into combat. Over six million women enter the workforce during the war, symbolized by 'Rosie the Riveter,' and more than 350,000 serve in the military itself. Faye discovers, with a rivet gun in her hands, that she is capable of exactly the work the world swore she couldn't do — and she is not going to forget it.

INSTITUTION

Total war • a whole country mobilized

Behind Faye stood an entire mobilized society, because total war demanded everyone. Civilians rationed sugar, meat, butter, and gasoline so supplies could go to the troops; they bought war bonds to finance the fight and joined scrap drives collecting metal and rubber. The Bracero Program brought millions of Mexican laborers to fill farm shortages, and government propaganda kept morale and unity high. The war reached into every kitchen, every gas tank, every backyard garden. Winning wasn't just something armies did overseas — it was something a hundred and thirty million people did at home, every single day.



📷 A woman operates a hand drill on a Vengeance dive bomber at the Vultee aircraft plant in Nashville, Tennessee, 1943 — a real 'Rosie the Riveter' on the Tennessee home front.
Palmer, Alfred T. 'Operating a hand drill at Vultee-Nashville, Tennessee.' U.S. Office of War Information photograph, February 1943. Public domain.

💡 This is a real 'Rosie' — a woman drilling a dive bomber at the Vultee plant in Nashville, Tennessee, in 1943. Ask: the government made and spread images like this on purpose. What message is it sending to women — and what happens to that message when the war ends and the men come home?

In plain words: World War II transformed the home front. With millions of men in the military, the defense industry hired women by the millions — over six million entered the workforce (symbolized by 'Rosie the Riveter'), building planes, ships, and weapons, and 350,000+ served in the military. Total war also required everyone else: civilians rationed food and gas, bought war bonds, and collected scrap. The Bracero Program brought Mexican farm workers, and propaganda kept up morale. Winning the war took the whole society, not just soldiers.

● **Tennessee:** That iconic 'Rosie' image was shot in Nashville. The Vultee aircraft plant there built dive bombers with a workforce full of Tennessee women. Nashville also produced one of the war's pioneering female aviators, Cornelia Fort — who was actually in the air over Pearl Harbor during the attack, later joined the Women Airforce Service Pilots, and became the first female pilot to die on active duty for the United States. Tennessee women didn't just support the war; they helped build and fly it.

✓ **Check:** Explain two major ways the war changed the American home front, including women's roles. Why might the government have promoted images like 'Rosie the Riveter,' and what happened to many women workers after the war?

Show what you know:

- Design a home-front poster (Rosie, rationing, or war bonds) and explain its persuasive techniques.
 - Write Faye's diary entry the day she out-drills a skeptical male coworker.
 - Debate: was 'Rosie the Riveter' a real step forward for women, or a temporary wartime necessity? Use evidence.
-

Analyze the internment of Japanese Americans under Executive Order 9066 as a grave civil-liberties violation driven by prejudice, not security.

🔔 You are an American citizen. You were born here, you pledge allegiance here, this is the only country you've ever known. Then one day the government gives your family a week to sell everything you own, pins a numbered tag to your coat like a piece of luggage, and locks you behind barbed wire in a desert — not for anything you did, but for the shape of your face and the country your grandparents came from. This happened. To 120,000 people. Here. And it is one of the hardest things this course will ask you to hold.

Archive brings the crew to a California street where families wait beside their suitcases, ID tags pinned to their coats. She's very quiet. 'Everything else this unit, America is fighting for freedom,' she says. 'Here, look carefully — because here it takes freedom away from its own citizens. Both are the same country, the same year.'



ERA-FRIEND

Kimi • a citizen behind barbed wire

Kimi is sixteen, born in California, as American as anyone in her school. After Pearl Harbor, a wave of fear and racial prejudice turns on Japanese Americans, and in 1942 President Roosevelt signs Executive Order 9066. Kimi's family is given days to sell their home and nursery, allowed one suitcase each, tagged with numbers, and shipped to a barbed-wire camp in a remote desert. About 120,000 people of Japanese ancestry are imprisoned this way — two-thirds of them U.S. citizens like Kimi — with no charges, no trials, no evidence of disloyalty. The cruelest part: even as Kimi sits behind the wire, her older brother volunteers for the U.S. Army, to prove a loyalty the country never should have doubted.

GROUP

The 442nd • loyalty the country didn't deserve

Kimi's brother joins the 442nd Regimental Combat Team, a unit of Japanese American soldiers — many with families locked in the very camps they left behind to serve. They fight in Europe with a ferocity born of having everything to prove, and the 442nd becomes the most decorated American unit of its size in the entire war. Their courage is a mirror held up to the country: these were the people America imprisoned as security threats, and they turned out to be among its bravest defenders. The injustice and the heroism belong to the same families, at the same time — which is exactly why internment is so shameful.



📷 The Mochida family — each member tagged for identification — waits for the bus to an internment camp, Hayward, California, May 1942, under Executive Order 9066.

Lange, Dorothea. 'Members of the Mochida family awaiting the evacuation bus, Hayward, California.' War Relocation Authority photograph, May 8, 1942. Public domain.

💡 This is the real Mochida family, tagged with ID numbers, waiting for the bus to a camp in 1942 — photographed by Dorothea Lange, whose internment images the Army tried to suppress. Ask: why would the government want to hide photographs like this one? What power does an honest image have that an official explanation doesn't?

In plain words: After Pearl Harbor, fear and racism turned against Japanese Americans. In 1942, Executive Order 9066 led the government to forcibly imprison about 120,000 people of Japanese ancestry — two-thirds of them U.S. citizens — in barbed-wire camps, with no charges, trials, or evidence of disloyalty. It was based on prejudice, not real security threats. The Supreme Court upheld it in *Korematsu v. United States* (1944). Meanwhile, Japanese American soldiers in the 442nd unit — some with families in the camps — became the most decorated unit of its size. In 1988, the U.S. apologized and paid reparations.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee offers a stark mirror to this injustice. Across the state — at Camp Forrest in Tullahoma and a camp at Crossville — Tennessee held thousands of German and Italian prisoners of war, actual enemy combatants, who were treated humanely under the rules of the Geneva Convention. Set that beside internment and the contrast is impossible to miss: the government extended legal protections to captured enemy soldiers that it denied to 120,000 of its own citizens, whose only 'crime' was their ancestry.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Wartime fear and racial prejudice led the government to imprison its own citizens without cause.
- **Head out of the sand:** The interned families themselves, Japanese American soldiers, photographers like Lange, and later civil-liberties advocates.
- **Voice raised:** Legal challenges (*Korematsu*), the documented record, the 442nd's service, and decades of redress activism.
- **Government response:** The government carried out internment and the Supreme Court upheld it; only in 1988 did Congress apologize and pay reparations.
- **Still unfinished:** Protecting civil liberties against fear and prejudice in wartime remains a live danger and duty.

✓ **Check:** Explain what Executive Order 9066 did and why historians say it was based on prejudice, not security. Then explain how the story of the 442nd Regiment makes the injustice even clearer. Why does the government's later apology matter?

Show what you know:

- Write a respectful reflection from Kimi's point of view on pledging allegiance to a flag flying over a prison camp.
- Compare the treatment of enemy POWs in Tennessee with the internment of Japanese American citizens, and explain what the contrast reveals.
- Explain, with evidence, why the 1988 apology and reparations were an important act for the country — and whether they were enough.

Analyze the Manhattan Project — including Oak Ridge, Tennessee — and the decision to drop the atomic bombs, weighing its justifications and its human cost.

🔊 A secret city rises in the Tennessee hills, so hidden it isn't on any map. Tens of thousands of people work there around the clock, most with no idea what they're making. What they're making is the power of the sun in a metal case — a single bomb that can erase a city in a heartbeat. When it's used, the war ends in days. And the world is never the same again. This is the hardest decision in this entire course, and it runs straight through Tennessee.

Archive brings the crew to the gates of a sprawling secret complex in the East Tennessee hills. 'The people inside these fences are ending the war,' she says, 'and most of them don't know how. When they find out, it will be one of the biggest arguments in human history. And it starts right here, in Tennessee.'



ERA-FRIEND

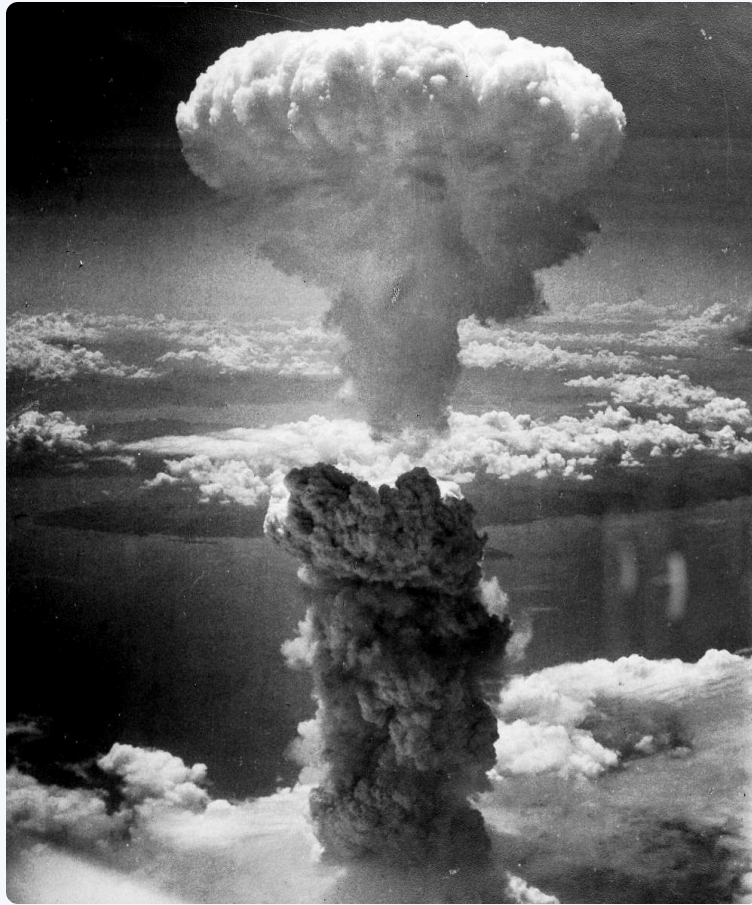
Hazel • the secret in the hills

Hazel is nineteen and takes the best-paying job she's ever heard of, in a brand-new town that appeared almost overnight on former farmland in East Tennessee: Oak Ridge, the 'Secret City.' She monitors dials and turns valves on equipment nobody will explain to her, sworn to secrecy, told only to do her job and ask no questions. Tens of thousands of workers around her are doing the same — enriching uranium, though almost none of them know that word. Hazel won't learn what her hands helped build until the morning the whole world learns it too: the day a single bomb, fed by Oak Ridge's uranium, destroys the Japanese city of Hiroshima.

INSTITUTION

The decision · victory and its price

In August 1945, President Truman made the most fateful choice in modern history. Atomic bombs destroyed Hiroshima on August 6 and Nagasaki on August 9, killing more than two hundred thousand people, most of them civilians, many instantly. Days later, Japan surrendered, ending World War II. Truman and his defenders argued the bombs prevented a land invasion of Japan that military planners feared could cost hundreds of thousands, even millions, of American and Japanese lives. Critics then and now argue that incinerating cities full of civilians was a moral catastrophe that can never be justified, and that Japan may have been near surrender. Both arguments are serious. This is not a question with an easy answer — and this unit will not pretend it is.



📷 The mushroom cloud over Nagasaki after the second atomic bomb, August 9, 1945 — the product of the Manhattan Project, including Oak Ridge, Tennessee.

'Mushroom cloud above Nagasaki after the atomic bombing.' U.S. Army Air Forces photograph, August 9, 1945.
Public domain.

💡 This is the mushroom cloud over Nagasaki, August 9, 1945. Ask: this single image contains both the end of the deadliest war in history and the deaths of tens of thousands of civilians. How do you hold both of those truths while looking at it — and how should a country remember a victory that looked like this?

In plain words: The top-secret Manhattan Project built the atomic bomb at three main sites, including Oak Ridge, Tennessee, where tens of thousands of workers enriched uranium without knowing what they were making. In August 1945, President Truman ordered atomic bombs dropped on Hiroshima (Aug. 6) and Nagasaki (Aug. 9), killing over 200,000 people, mostly civilians. Japan surrendered days later, ending the war. The decision is still debated: supporters say it avoided an invasion that could have killed millions more; critics say destroying civilian cities was a moral catastrophe. It began the nuclear age.

● **Tennessee:** The atomic bomb runs straight through Tennessee. On former East Tennessee farmland the government built Oak Ridge, a secret city of tens of thousands that enriched the uranium for the Hiroshima bomb. Most of the workers — Tennesseans and people drawn from across the country — had no idea what they were building until the news broke. Oak Ridge swelled almost overnight into one of Tennessee's largest communities, and it made the state a birthplace of the nuclear age.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Ending the deadliest war raised the question of whether to use a weapon that could destroy whole cities.
- **Head out of the sand:** Scientists, military planners, and a new president weighing invasion casualties against a terrible weapon.
- **Voice raised:** The decision was made in secret at the highest levels; public and historians have debated it ever since.
- **Government response:** Truman ordered the bombs used; Japan surrendered, and the nuclear age and arms race began.
- **Still unfinished:** Whether the bombings were justified — and how to control nuclear weapons — remains debated to this day.

✓ **Check:** Explain what the Manhattan Project was and Tennessee's role in it. Then lay out the strongest argument FOR and AGAINST dropping the atomic bombs, and take your own position with evidence.

Show what you know:

- Write two short op-eds dated August 1945 — one defending the bomb, one condemning it — each making its strongest case.
 - Research Oak Ridge and explain what it was like to work there without knowing the project's purpose.
 - Hold a structured debate on the atomic-bomb decision, then write your own evidence-based verdict.
-

Spread 9 · US.57, US.58

Analyze the Yalta Conference and the tensions leading to the Cold War, and the founding of the United Nations as America's renewed commitment to the world.

 The war is finally ending, and three men sit for a photograph that will shape the next fifty years. They're supposed to be allies, planning the peace together — but two of them are about to become enemies in a new kind of war, one fought with spies and threats instead of armies. And out of the same moment comes humanity's second great attempt to outlaw war itself, an idea a Tennessean spent his whole life building. The war's ending holds both the seed of the Cold War and the best hope for peace — at once.

Last stop in the war. Archive sets the crew at Yalta as the Big Three pose, then jumps to San Francisco as delegates rise to their feet. 'Watch two futures being born in the same season,' she says. 'One is a standoff that will last your grandparents' whole lives. The other is a promise the whole world makes to itself — helped into being by a man from Tennessee.'

INSTITUTION

Yalta · the seeds of the Cold War

In February 1945, with victory in sight, the 'Big Three' — Roosevelt, Churchill, and Stalin — met at Yalta to plan the war's end. They agreed to divide Germany into occupation zones, to hold free elections in the liberated countries of Europe, and to create a new international organization. But beneath the handshakes ran a deep divide: the democratic West and Stalin's communist USSR did not trust each other, and Stalin soon broke his promise of free elections, clamping Soviet control onto Eastern Europe. The alliance that beat Hitler was already cracking. Out of Yalta's broken promises grew the Cold War — the tense, decades-long standoff that opens your next unit.

GROUP

The United Nations • trying again

Even as the Cold War took shape, the world made its boldest bid for peace. Determined not to repeat the League of Nations' failure — the one the U.S. had refused to join back in Unit 3 — the Allies founded the United Nations in 1945, its charter signed in San Francisco, built around a Security Council and a General Assembly meant to stop the next world war before it started. Its charter opens with a vow 'to save succeeding generations from the scourge of war.' And this time, the United States did not walk away. After two catastrophic world wars in thirty years, America committed to staying engaged with the world — the very thing it had refused to do in 1919.



📷 The 'Big Three' — Churchill, Roosevelt, and Stalin — at the Yalta Conference, February 1945, planning the end of the war and the postwar world.

'The Big Three (Churchill, Roosevelt, Stalin) at the Yalta Conference.' U.S. Army Signal Corps photograph, February 1945. Public domain.

💡 This is the 'Big Three' at Yalta in February 1945 — Churchill, Roosevelt, Stalin, allies for a few more weeks. It's one of the last photos of FDR alive. Ask: everyone in this picture is smiling, but two of these nations are about to become bitter enemies. What can a friendly photograph hide about what people are really thinking?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



Representatives of 26 Allied nations sign the 'Declaration by United Nations' in Washington, January 1, 1942 — the first official use of the name 'United Nations.'

In plain words: As the war ended, the 'Big Three' (Roosevelt, Churchill, Stalin) met at Yalta in February 1945 to plan the peace: divide Germany, hold free elections in liberated Europe, and create the United Nations. But the democratic West and communist USSR distrusted each other, and Stalin soon broke his promise of free elections, taking over Eastern Europe — the start of the Cold War. At the same time, the Allies founded the United Nations (1945) to prevent future wars, learning from the failed League of Nations. This time, the U.S. committed to staying engaged with the world.

● **Tennessee:** The United Nations had a Tennessee father. Cordell Hull — the Tennessean you've now followed from the failed League of Nations in Unit 3, through his years as FDR's Secretary of State — did more than anyone to design the postwar UN. FDR himself called Hull the 'Father of the United Nations,' and Hull won the 1945 Nobel Peace Prize for the work. The dream of collective security that died in the Senate in 1919 came back to life in 1945 — with a man from the Tennessee hills as its architect.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** After the deadliest war in history, the world needed both to settle the peace and to prevent the next war.
- **Head out of the sand:** Allied leaders at Yalta and San Francisco, and internationalists like Cordell Hull.
- **Voice raised:** Wartime diplomacy, the UN Charter, and U.S. commitment to join this time.
- **Government response:** The Allies created occupation zones and founded the United Nations; the U.S. joined and stayed engaged.
- **Still unfinished:** The Cold War divided the world for decades, and the UN's power to actually prevent war remains limited and debated.

✓ **Check:** Explain what was decided at Yalta and how it helped lead to the Cold War. Then explain why the United Nations was founded and how it differed from the U.S. response after World War I. What is Tennessee's connection?

Show what you know:

- Compare the U.S. response to the League of Nations (Unit 3) with the United Nations (this unit) in a short chart.
- Write the speech Cordell Hull might give accepting the Nobel Peace Prize, tying his 1919 hopes to 1945.
- Debate: was the United Nations doomed to be as weak as the League, or a real improvement? Use evidence.

Toward a more perfect union

World War II is the sharpest test yet of the 'more perfect union' question, because the contradiction is right on the surface: the United States led the fight to destroy fascism and save democracy in the world — and did it with a segregated army, a defense industry it had to be forced to integrate, and 120,000 of its own citizens locked in camps for their ancestry. Both are true. The country was, at the same moment, freedom's greatest champion and a place where freedom was rationed by race. Watch the war expose that gap so plainly that it becomes impossible to ignore — planting the seeds of the civil-rights movement to come. And watch victory arrive carrying the heaviest moral weight in the whole course: a weapon, built partly in Tennessee, that ended the war by incinerating two cities.

Closing question: World War II showed the United States at its best and its worst at the very same time. Choose one example of the country fighting for freedom and one of it denying freedom, and argue what the war, on balance, did to the nation's founding promise. Then take a position on the hardest question in the unit: was the United States right to drop the atomic bombs? Cite the unit — there's no answer key.

This unit on the Arc of the Union

You decide: did each of these move the country **toward** its founding promise of liberty and equality for all — or away from it? There's no answer key — mark your own read and defend it with evidence.

Year	Milestone	What happened	Your call
1933	Fascism seizes power in Germany	Hitler's dictatorship menaces the world's democracies and targets its own people.	
1941	Pearl Harbor brings the U.S. into the war	A surprise attack ends isolationism and commits America to a two-front war.	
1942	Executive Order 9066 interns Japanese Americans	A democracy fighting for freedom imprisons its own citizens by ancestry.	
1944	D-Day opens the road to victory in Europe	The largest invasion in history opens the western front against Nazi Germany.	
1945	The Double V and the seeds of civil rights	Fighting fascism abroad sharpens the demand for freedom at home.	
1945	The atomic bomb ends the war	A weapon built partly in Tennessee ends the war and opens the nuclear era.	
1945	The United Nations is founded	Learning from the League's failure, the world tries again — with a Tennessean as architect.	